

PA.2 Permit Application Checklist

What goes in the application, how long the reviewer has, and the Pennsylvania amendments that make the code book on your desk wrong in places that matter.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Pennsylvania is not a no-code state and it is not a no-inspection state: the Uniform Construction Code applies to every house in the Commonwealth, and five inspections are required on every one of them. What changes from one municipality to the next is *who performs them* — a municipal code official, an agency the municipality retained, or, where the municipality elected not to administer the code at all, an agency **you** hire yourself. Fees, review queues and the local permits stacked on top of the building permit vary too. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it.

Pennsylvania publishes no statewide building permit application form. The form is the municipality's or the third-party agency's, and it varies. What does not vary is **what the regulation entitles the reviewer to demand**, and that list is short enough to work through before you go anywhere near a counter.

WHAT THE APPLICATION MUST CARRY

34 Pa. Code § 403.62a — the residential permit application

Item	What the regulation requires	Cite
Construction documents	Plans and specifications, submitted to the building code official. The official may waive them where the nature of the work does not require review — which will not be the case for a house.	§ 403.62a(b), (c)
A site plan	Showing “the size and location of the new construction and existing structures on the site and the structures' distance from lot lines.” This is a code requirement in its own right, not a courtesy sketch.	§ 403.62a(e)
Every other permit or approval	All other permits or approvals related to the construction. In practice this is where your sewage permit, zoning approval, driveway permit and stormwater approval get collected.	§ 403.62a(b)
Flood hazard information	If the lot is in a mapped flood hazard area: the flood hazard and floodway boundaries, flood zones, the design flood elevation, and the proposed lowest floor elevation including basement. In a Zone AO shallow-flooding area, the height above highest adjacent grade as well.	§ 403.62a(d)

Note the section number. § 403.62a governs **residential** permit applications; § 403.42a is the near-identical commercial section, and the two are easy to cite in place of one another. The residential permit and inspection sections are §§ 403.61—403.66.

THE REVIEW CLOCK — AND HOW TO CUT IT TO FIVE DAYS

Pennsylvania puts the reviewer on a statutory clock and attaches a real consequence to missing it. For a one- or two-family dwelling the code official must grant or deny the application, in whole or in part, **within 15 business days of the filing date** — and if he fails to act within that time, **“the application shall be deemed approved.”**

The five-day route is worth more than it costs

The same sentence sets a much shorter clock on one condition: where “the drawings have been prepared by design professionals who are licensed or registered under the laws and regulations of this Commonwealth **and the application contains a certification by the licensed or registered design professional that the plans meet the applicable standards** of the Uniform Construction Code and ordinance as appropriate,” the deadline is **five business days**.

Pennsylvania does not otherwise require a house to be designed by an architect or engineer. So the seal is optional — but buying one converts a three-week review into a one-week review, and the certification language has to be on the application for the short clock to run. If you are paying a design professional anyway, ask specifically for that certification.

Two more timing facts from the same section. Once the plan is approved, the code administrator “shall issue a building permit **immediately upon receipt of all other required permits or approvals** related to the construction” — so plan approval and permit issuance are separate events, and the gap between them is filled by your septic, driveway and zoning paperwork. And any revision to approved plans “shall necessitate an additional plan review prior to the issuing of the building permit.”

Ask for the list — then verify it yourself

Section 7210.502(a)(1) requires that **“the municipality shall also provide a list of all other required permits necessary prior to issuance of the building permit.”** Ask for it in writing; it is the fastest way to discover the approvals your particular lot triggers.

Then read the next sentence, which is the reason PA.4 exists: **“The municipality will not be liable for the completeness of any list.”** A missing item on that list is still your problem, and still stops your permit.

WHAT CODE YOU ARE ACTUALLY BUILDING TO

Editions in force — effective 1 January 2026

System	Adopted edition	Cite
One- and two-family dwellings	2021 International Residential Code , with the Pennsylvania exclusions and modifications below	§ 403.21(a)(7)
Energy	2021 International Energy Conservation Code — but with Pennsylvania's own replacement envelope tables	§ 403.21(a)(9)
Electrical	The electrical chapters of the 2021 IRC (Chapters 34—43). Pennsylvania does not adopt NFPA 70 by reference at all — see below	§ 403.21(a)(7)
Plumbing	IRC plumbing provisions for a dwelling; the 2021 International Plumbing Code otherwise — except in Allegheny County , which runs its own plumbing code	§ 403.21(a)(6)
Mechanical and fuel gas	2021 International Mechanical Code and 2021 International Fuel Gas Code	§ 403.21(a)(3), (4)
Wall bracing	The 2006 IRC . Not a typo — see the amendments table	35 P.S. § 7210.304(i)

If you check this on L&I's website, you may be told 2018

The 2021 codes were adopted by a regulation published at 55 Pa.B. 7701, amending 34 Pa. Code § 403.21 on 7 November 2025, effective 1 January 2026. As this kit went to press the Department's own Uniform Construction Code home page still described the 2018 I-Code series with an effective date of 14 February 2022 — the previous cycle. **The regulation governs, not the web page.** Read 34 Pa. Code § 403.21 at pacodeandbulletin.gov and check the Pennsylvania Bulletin line at the top of the chapter for how current it is.

One transitional rule matters if your project straddles the date: under § 403.1(a)(2), work for which a design or construction contract was executed before the effective date of the amendment complies with the codes in effect when that contract was signed.

THE PENNSYLVANIA AMENDMENTS THAT CHANGE THE BUILDING

These are differences from the printed model code, not restatements of it. Each one is a place where building to the book fails inspection, or where the book demands something Pennsylvania does not.

Differences between the printed 2021 IRC and Pennsylvania law

Subject	What Pennsylvania actually requires	Authority
Wall bracing	The 2009 IRC bracing provisions “ and successor provisions ” are excluded from the UCC, and the wall bracing requirements of 2006 IRC sections R602.10—R602.11.3 are what Pennsylvania enforces. Your 2021 code book's bracing chapter is not the law here.	35 P.S. § 7210.304(i)
Floor membrane	A floor assembly not required to be fire-resistance rated must carry 1/2-inch gypsum wallboard, a 5/8-inch wood structural panel, or equivalent on the underside of the floor framing . Exceptions: space below is sprinklered; a crawl space not used for storage or fuel-fired appliances; up to 80 sq ft per story left unprotected if fireblocked at its perimeter; and dimension lumber or structural composite lumber of 2×10 nominal or greater. This is the I-joist rule , and it is in the statute rather than the code book.	35 P.S. § 7210.304(h)
No sprinkler mandate	IRC § R313.2 “and any successor triennial revisions” is excluded from the Act. Pennsylvania does not require automatic fire sprinklers in a one- or two-family dwelling. A builder must still offer the option in writing at or before a purchase contract, with cost information — relevant if you later build to sell.	35 P.S. § 7210.304(g)
Stairs are steeper here	Maximum riser 8¼ inches , minimum tread 9 inches — both more permissive than the model code. Riser variation within a flight no more than 3/8 inch; greatest tread depth no more than 3/8 inch over the smallest; minimum 3 ft clear width; 6 ft 8 in headroom; handrails may project 3½ inches each side.	34 Pa. Code § 403.21 (a)(7)(ii)
Vapor retarder	The under-slab vapor retarder requirement is reduced from the 2021 IRC's 10-mil ASTM E1745 Class A sheet to 6 mil .	34 Pa. Code § 403.21 (a)(7)(iv)(E)
No radon provisions	Appendices to the adopted codes “are not adopted” except for the existing-building code and two IBC appendices. IRC Appendix F, radon-resistant construction, is therefore not part of the UCC — no passive radon system is required anywhere in Pennsylvania by the building code, in a state with high radon. Building one is a choice, and a cheap one before the slab goes down.	34 Pa. Code § 403.21(c)

Differences between the printed 2021 IRC and Pennsylvania law

Subject	What Pennsylvania actually requires	Authority
Three receptacle rules rolled back	Pennsylvania excludes three 2021 IRC electrical sections and puts older text back in their place — see the electrical table below. Island countertops, tub and shower space, and foyers are all governed by earlier editions than the book your electrician is working from.	34 Pa. Code § 403.21 (a)(7)(iii), (vi), (viii)
Other exclusions	Also excluded: R311.7.4 (stair walkline), R325.5 (openness), R703.7 (exterior plaster and stucco), R806.2 (minimum ventilation area) and R1005.8 (chimney insulation shield). R314.4 (smoke alarm interconnection) is excluded as well, and for alterations, repairs and additions the regulation substitutes non-interconnected battery-operated alarms — confirm with your official what he expects on new work.	34 Pa. Code § 403.21 (a)(7)(i), (iii)

Two sources, deliberately. The Department amends the codes by regulation at 34 Pa. Code § 403.21; the General Assembly wrote several technical rules directly into the Act itself in 2011, and those live at 35 P.S. § 7210.304 where nobody looks for them. Wall bracing, the floor membrane and the sprinkler exclusion are all statutory.

ENERGY — PENNSYLVANIA REWROTE THE TABLE

Pennsylvania did not adopt the 2021 IECC envelope tables. It replaced them. The values below are Pennsylvania's own Table R402.1.3 as printed in the regulation, for the three climate zones found in the Commonwealth. **Confirm your zone with your code official** — under 34 Pa. Code § 403.103(d) it is the building code official who determines the climatic and geographic design criteria in IRC Table R301.2(1).

Pennsylvania Table R402.1.3 — minimum insulation and fenestration

Component	Zone 4	Zone 5	Zone 6
Ceiling	R-49	R-49	R-49
Wood frame wall	R-20, or 13+5	R-23, or 13+7.5, or 20+3.8	R-20+5, or 13+10
Floor	R-19	R-30	R-30
Basement wall	10/13	15/19	15/19
Crawl space wall	10/13	15/19	15/19
Slab R-value & depth	R-10, 2 ft	R-10, 4 ft or R-15, 3 ft	R-10, 4 ft
Window U-factor	0.32	0.30	0.30
Glazed SHGC	0.40	NR	NR
Blower door	3.0 ACH50	3.0 ACH50	3.0 ACH50

34 Pa. Code § 403.21(a)(9)(vi)(D), Table R402.1.3. Skylights are U-0.55 in all three zones. Two-number entries follow the table's own footnotes: "13+5" means R-13 cavity plus R-5 continuous insulation; "10/13" means R-10 continuous or R-13 cavity, and "15/19" may alternatively be met with R-13 cavity plus R-5 continuous. A floor may alternatively be insulated to fill the framing cavity at not less than R-19. Zone 4 values are the "except Marine" row. The air leakage limit is 2021 IECC R402.4.1.2, which Pennsylvania did not amend: 3 air changes per hour in Climate Zones 3 through 8, which is all of Pennsylvania.

Three energy details worth money

The ceiling stayed at R-49. The unamended 2021 IECC would have required R-60 in these zones; Pennsylvania's replacement table keeps R-49. Do not let a supplier upsell you to a national number your code does not ask for — but do not assume the reverse either, since a municipality may adopt a stricter ordinance.

The blower door is real and it is 3.0. Any guide quoting 5.0 or 4.0 ACH50 for Pennsylvania is repeating a figure from an older code cycle. Air sealing to 5.0 and testing at 3.0 is a failed test and a scramble.

Duct leakage testing has two Pennsylvania exceptions. Under the amended R403.3.5 no duct air-leakage test is required where the ducts and air handlers are entirely within the building thermal envelope, or for ducts serving heat or energy recovery ventilators not integrated with the heating or cooling ducts. Designing the ducts inside the envelope removes a test and a failure mode.

For compliance you may use REScheck, or a Pennsylvania-specific prescriptive package called **"Pennsylvania's Alternative Residential Energy Provisions"**, both named in the regulation at 34 Pa. Code § 403.21(d)(1). The performance and energy-rating-index paths exist but Pennsylvania has excluded and rewritten large parts of them, so the prescriptive route is the predictable one for an owner-builder.

ELECTRICAL — THERE IS NO NEC EDITION TO LOOK UP

This surprises electricians as often as owners. **The Pennsylvania UCC adopts no edition of NFPA 70, the National Electrical Code, for residential work.** The phrases "NFPA 70" and "National Electrical Code" do not appear in 34 Pa. Code Chapter 403 at all. What governs the wiring in a Pennsylvania house is **Chapters 34 through 43 of the 2021 IRC** (sections E3401—E4304). Every Pennsylvania electrical amendment is written in those E-section numbers, which is the proof of it. So if a guide tells you Pennsylvania is "on the 2020 NEC," treat that as background trivia rather than a citation — there is no such adoption to point at, and quoting an NEC article number to a Pennsylvania inspector will not settle an argument.

That matters less than the next point, which is where Pennsylvania actually catches people. The Commonwealth did not simply delete three receptacle rules — it **replaced them with the text of earlier editions**. Everything else in Chapters 34—43, including all the AFCI and GFCI requirements and service sizing, is the 2021 IRC as published.

The four electrical sections Pennsylvania changed

Section	What governs instead	Cite
E3901.4.2 Island and peninsula countertop spaces	2021 text excluded. The 2018 IRC version governs. The 2021 edition substantially rewrote island receptacle rules; Pennsylvania rejected the rewrite.	§ 403.21(a)(7)(iii)(KK); (viii)(J)
E4002.11 Bathtub and shower space	2021 text excluded. The 2018 IRC version governs.	§ 403.21(a)(7)(iii)(MM); (viii)(K)
E3901.11 Foyers	2021 text excluded. The 2015 IRC version governs, further modified so the trigger reads 6 feet rather than 3 feet, with a minimum of one receptacle.	§ 403.21(a)(7)(iii)(LL); (vi)(O)
E4004.5 Means of support	Adopted as modified — the internal cross-reference to E3906.12 is replaced with E3905.6.3.	§ 403.21(a)(7)(iv)(NN)

Mark these four in your code book before the rough-in. Island countertop receptacles, tub and shower clearance and foyer receptacles are three of the most routinely inspected residential electrical items, and all three are places where a current 2021 IRC — and current training — will give a Pennsylvania electrician the wrong answer.

ONCE THE PERMIT IS ISSUED

- **180 days to start.** A permit becomes invalid unless authorized work begins within 180 days of issuance, or if work is suspended or abandoned for 180 days after commencing. Extensions must be requested in writing and granted in writing (34 Pa. Code § 403.63(g)).
- **Five years, maximum.** “A permit may be valid for no more than 5 years from its issue date” — the outer limit on a slow owner-built project (§ 403.63(g)).
- **Keep the permit and the stamped plans on site.** The permit holder keeps a copy of the permit on the work site until construction is complete, and a copy of the reviewed construction documents open to inspection (§§ 403.63(c), (h)).
- **A foundation-only permit is available.** The official may issue a permit for foundations before the documents for the whole building are submitted — useful for a long build, though it is expressly no assurance the rest will be approved (§ 403.63(e)).
- **Changes require a new review.** Work must be installed per the approved documents; a revised set must be submitted and approved for changes made during construction (§ 403.63(j)).

Before you file

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Confirmed who reviews and inspects — municipal office or third-party agency (PA.1) Name _____		

Before you file

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Obtained the municipality's written list of all other required permits Date requested _____ Received _____		
☐	Site plan drawn showing all structures and their distances from every lot line		
☐	Sewage permit issued, or public sewer connection confirmed (see PA.4) Permit no. _____		
☐	Driveway: highway occupancy permit applied for if the lot touches a state highway Applied _____ Issued _____		
☐	Zoning approval obtained from the municipality		
☐	Flood hazard status checked; elevation data prepared if the lot is in a mapped area		
☐	Climate zone confirmed with the code official, and the energy compliance path chosen Zone _____ Path _____		
☐	Plans checked against the Pennsylvania amendments above — especially wall bracing and the floor membrane		
☐	Decided whether to obtain a design professional's certification for the five-business-day review		

Sources — every Pennsylvania claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Residential permit application contents; site plan; flood data	34 Pa. Code § 403.62a
15 business days, or 5 with a design professional's certification	35 P.S. § 7210.502(a)(1); 34 Pa. Code § 403.63(a)
Failure to act means the application is deemed approved	35 P.S. § 7210.502(a)(3)
Municipality must list other required permits; not liable for the list	35 P.S. § 7210.502(a)(1)
2021 I-Codes adopted; effective 1 January 2026	34 Pa. Code § 403.21; 55 Pa.B. 7701

Sources — every Pennsylvania claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Contract signed before the amendment keeps the older codes	34 Pa. Code § 403.1(a)(2)
Appendices not adopted — no IRC Appendix F radon requirement	34 Pa. Code § 403.21(c)
Stair riser and tread; struck IRC provisions; vapor retarder	34 Pa. Code § 403.21(a)(7)
Wall bracing enforced from the 2006 IRC	35 P.S. § 7210.304(i)
Floor membrane requirement and its exceptions	35 P.S. § 7210.304(h)
Residential sprinklers excluded; builder's offer duty	35 P.S. § 7210.304(g)
Pennsylvania's replacement energy tables	34 Pa. Code § 403.21(a)(9)(vi)
Compliance via REScheck or PA Alternative Residential Energy Provisions	34 Pa. Code § 403.21(d)(1)
Code official sets the climatic and geographic design criteria	34 Pa. Code § 403.103(d)
Permit life: 180 days, 5 years; foundation-only permits; revisions	34 Pa. Code § 403.63

Every source cited here is free to read, but Pennsylvania keeps statutes and regulations on **two different websites**. A citation reading **Pa. Code** is a regulation — pacodeandbulletin.gov, by title and chapter. A citation reading **P.S.** is a statute, and it is **not on that site at all**; the Pa. Code home page says so outright. Statutes are at legis.state.pa.us → Unconsolidated Statutes, by year and act number — the Construction Code Act is Act 45 of 1999. **One warning:** every Pa. Code chapter prints the Pennsylvania Bulletin issue it is current through, and an amendment published later is already law. Read that line first. All text here was read at those sources, September 2026.